Baul singers, a legacy of the Bhakti tradition, who sing Sufi-inspired folk songs in praise of a universal God. Muslim sociologists and anthropologists have argued that Islam in rural India is more Indian than Islamic, in the sense that the faith as practised by the ordinary Muslim villagers reflects the considerable degree of cultural assimilation that has occurred between Hindus and Muslims in their daily lives. The late Muslim reformist scholar Asghar Ali Engineer once wrote that 'rural Islam… [is] almost indistinguishable from Hinduism except in the form of worship…. The degree may vary from one area to another; but cultural integration between the Hindus and Muslims is a fact which no one, except victims of misinformation, can deny.'

One of the most striking images of India that went around the internet in recent years was a photograph of a Muslim couple on Janmashtami day setting out on their scooter, the man with a beard and skullcap, the woman in all-encompassing burqa, taking their child to act in a school performance—and this Muslim boy was dressed as Krishna, complete with kiritam, peacock feather, blue-hued skin and flute.

Sadly, some Hindu chauvinists have distorted the basic tenets of their own religion—as described in the preceding chapters—to propagate a version of the faith in opposition to other religions, especially Islam and Christianity. Worse, this violent, extremist brand of Hinduism, which has no sanction in Hindu scriptures, theology or practice, appears to be gaining ground in recent times, with the covert or active assistance of many Hindutva-inclined politicians, religious leaders and groups. The two worst examples of these affronts to the spirit of Hinduism in modern times are undoubtedly, as I have mentioned, the demolition of the Babri Masjid in December 1991 by a howling, chanting mob of fanatics, and the massacre of innocents, mainly Muslims, in Gujarat in 2002.

What have we come to, that a land that has been a haven of tolerance for religious minorities throughout its history should have sunk so low? India's is a civilisation that, over millennia, has offered refuge and, more importantly, religious and cultural freedom, to Jews, Parsis, Muslims and several varieties of Christians. Christianity arrived on Indian soil, or so legend has it, with St Thomas the Apostle ('Doubting Thomas'), who is said to have come to the Kerala coast some time before 52 CE and was